# Habib Watamama Macaayong

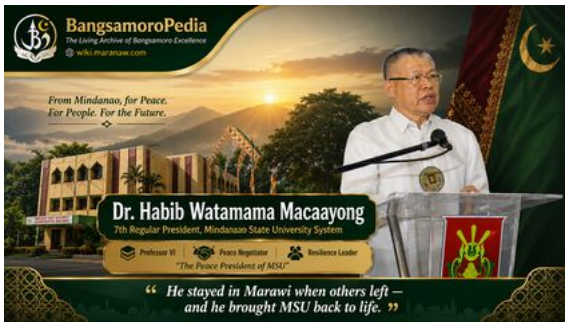
**Habib Watamama Macaayong** (also written as **Habib W. Macaayong**) is a distinguished Meranaw academician, administrator, and peace advocate from Bacolod-Kalawi, Lanao del Sur.

He served as the **7th Regular President** (10th overall) of the Mindanao State University (MSU) System from 2016 to 2022, leading the country's most prominent Muslim-majority university through some of its most defining and difficult chapters.<ref name="pia2021">Philippine Information Agency. (2021, October 28). *Macaayong underscores MSU System's administrative reforms.* https://mirror.pia.gov.ph/news/2021/10/28/macaayong-underscores-msu-systems-administrative-reforms</ref>

In the Bangsamoro world, Dr. Macaayong is remembered as a president who showed up when it mattered most. He stayed on campus during the five-month Marawi Siege of 2017, rallied the community with the "Balik MSU" campaign, and made MSU-Marawi the first city institution to reopen its gates after the battle, turning rubble into resolve.

Beyond crisis leadership, he spent decades shaping policy at the national level, having chaired the technical working group on power sharing during the historic Government-MILF peace negotiations from 2004 to 2013.

His peers and the communities he served have called him the **"Peace President"** of Mindanao State University, a title that speaks to both his role in formal negotiations and his quiet, persistent work of keeping a university together across lines of faith, politics, and conflict.

| **Habib Watamama Macaayong** | |
|---|---|
|  | |
| **Born** | Bacolod-Kalawi, Lanao del Sur, Philippines |
| **Ethnicity** | Meranaw |
| **Nationality** | Filipino |
| **Occupation** | Academician, Administrator, Peace Advocate |
| **Known for** | 7th Regular President (10th Overall) of the Mindanao State University System |
| **Tenure** | 2016 to 2022 |
| **Institution** | Mindanao State University System |
| **Specialization** | Governance, Public Administration, Peace and Development |
| **Affiliation** | Mindanao State University |

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# Background

Dr. Macaayong's roots run deep in the Lanao region.

A proud son of **Bacolod-Kalawi** in Lanao del Sur, he belongs to the **Meranaw** ethnic group, one of the thirteen recognized Bangsamoro peoples and the primary inhabitants of the Lake Lanao basin.

His upbringing in this culturally rich and politically complex region shaped his worldview early on, giving him a direct, lived understanding of what it means to navigate identity, faith, and governance in Muslim Mindanao.

Those roots never left him, even as his career took him to national policy rooms and international dialogue tables. They kept him grounded in the realities of the community that MSU was always meant to serve.<ref name="fb-kimalo">Abdullah, K. M. (n.d.). *Post about Habib W. Macaayong.* Facebook. https://www.facebook.com/KimalodenMayonAbdullah/posts/122171562620893556/</ref>

# Education

Dr. Macaayong built his academic foundation in governance and public administration, disciplines that prepared him equally for the classroom, the negotiating table, and the president's office.

The specific institutions and degrees earned are consistent with the profile of a career academic who rose through the ranks of the MSU system over more than three decades of teaching and research.

# Early Career at SPDA (1975–1981)

Immediately following his graduation from Mindanao State University (MSU) in 1975, Dr. Habib Watamama Macaayong began his professional career with the Southern Philippines Development Administration (now Authority or SPDA). His employment at SPDA is historically significant as the agency was established that same year—on April 22, 1975, via Presidential Decree No. 690—to address the economic and social development of Mindanao, Sulu, and Tawi-Tawi.

As a young graduate in Public Administration, Macaayong joined SPDA during its foundational years. His role was aligned with the agency's primary mandate to foster balanced growth and national integration in the region.

• Project Involvement: During his tenure, he was involved in the early implementation of corporate and social projects, ranging from agro-industrial ventures to peace and development initiatives. • Transition to Academe: His practical experience in regional development at SPDA served as a bridge to his academic career; he transitioned from government administration to the Mindanao State University as a professor in 1981.

# Academic Career

Before taking on the presidency, Dr. Macaayong had already given more than thirty years of his professional life to Mindanao State University.

He joined the MSU College of Public Affairs as a faculty member in **1981** and rose to the rank of **Professor VI**, the highest rank in the Philippine professorial system, teaching governance, public administration, and policy for over 35 years.<ref name="msuiit-news">MSU-IIT Information Office. (n.d.). *News detail.* https://www.msuiit.edu.ph/news/news-detail.php?id=771</ref>

That kind of tenure, three and a half decades in the same institution, isn't just longevity. It's a record of trust, a sign that he kept growing and that his students and colleagues kept coming back.

His classroom work was paired with serious national engagement. From 2004 to 2013, Dr. Macaayong served as chairman of the technical working group on power sharing during the **GPH-MILF peace negotiations**, contributing directly to the policy architecture that would eventually shape the Bangsamoro peace process.

It was rare, and significant, for an academic to hold that kind of role in formal negotiations, and it reflected the depth of his expertise in governance and his standing in both Muslim and national circles.

# Presidency of the MSU System (2016 to 2022)

Dr. Macaayong was appointed as the **7th Regular President** (10th overall) of the Mindanao State University System in **2016**, a position he held until **2022**.<ref name="inquirer-naming">Inquirer News. (n.d.). *Naming of new MSU president draws fire.* https://newsinfo.inquirer.net/780806/naming-of-new-msu-president-draws-fire</ref>

His six-year tenure was one of the most eventful in the university's history, bracketed on one side by a major armed conflict and on the other by a global pandemic.

## Leadership During the 2017 Marawi Siege

When the Marawi Siege broke out in May 2017, most people were trying to leave the city. Dr. Macaayong stayed.

He remained on campus throughout the five-month conflict, overseeing security operations and working to protect what he could of the university's people, assets, and continuity.

When the dust settled, he launched the **"Balik MSU"** campaign, a community-driven initiative to bring students, faculty, and staff back to campus.

The result was historic: MSU-Marawi became the **first institution in Marawi City to reopen** after the siege, a powerful symbol of institutional resilience and Meranaw determination in the face of extremism.

In a city where entire neighborhoods had been reduced to rubble, the reopening of MSU was more than a logistical achievement. It was a statement that the community would not be defined by the siege.

## COVID-19 Response

When the COVID-19 pandemic struck in 2020 and disrupted academic life across the country, Dr. Macaayong's administration responded with a policy that prioritized students over bureaucratic convention.

The **Mass Promotion policy of 2020** allowed students to move forward in their academic journey despite the disruptions of the pandemic, acknowledging both the academic and financial hardships that families across the MSU system were facing.

It was a pragmatic, compassionate call, and it reflected a consistent thread in his leadership: when rules and realities collide, he leaned toward the people.

## Infrastructure and Campus Modernization

One of the most visible legacies of his presidency is the physical transformation of the MSU system's campuses.

Under Dr. Macaayong's watch, the university completed major construction and modernization projects, including the **Science and Technology Building**, the **College of Social Sciences and Humanities Building**, and the installation of a **campus-wide fiber optic network**.

These weren't cosmetic upgrades. They were investments in the university's capacity to teach, research, and compete, laying the groundwork for academic programs to qualify for higher accreditation levels in the years that followed.

## Personnel Reform and Faculty Promotion

One of the quieter but deeply consequential reforms of his administration was the revival of the university's **Merit Selection Board**.

By reactivating the board and instituting a transparent promotion process, Dr. Macaayong's administration was able to push through the **massive promotion of over 900 faculty members**, some of whom had been stuck in the same rank for decades.<ref name="pia2021"/><ref name="fb-ateshy">Facebook Post. (n.d.). *Former MSU President Habib W. Macaayong: a transformative leader.* https://www.facebook.com/ateshy143/posts/former-msu-president-habib-w-macaayong-a-transformative-leader-who-built-a-lasti/1547883490318048/</ref>

For those faculty members and their families, it was a life-changing development. For the university, it was a reset: a recommitment to merit as the basis of advancement, not politics or seniority alone.

## Academic Accreditation and Quality Assurance

Under Dr. Macaayong, the MSU System made aggressive strides in program accreditation and compliance.

By the end of his term in 2021, **MSU-Marawi** was recognized by the **Accrediting Agency of Chartered Colleges and Universities in the Philippines (AACCUP)** as the **Top 1 Performing State University and College (SUC)** in the country, based on the highest number of Level I accredited programs, reaching a milestone of **40 Level I programs**.<ref name="fb-msumain">Mindanao State University Main Campus. (n.d.). *MSU-Marawi cited as Top 1 Performing SUC.* Facebook. https://www.facebook.com/msumain.edu.ph/posts/the-mindanao-state-university-main-campus-in-marawi-city-has-been-awarded-as-the/4837256936329044/</ref>

His administration also advanced the system's pursuit of Level IV accreditation (the highest AACCUP tier, benchmarked against excellent foreign universities), with key programs at **MSU-Iligan Institute of Technology (MSU-IIT)** reaching or maintaining that elite status during his tenure.

These programs included Bachelor of Arts in English, Filipino, History, Political Science, and Sociology; Bachelor of Science in Psychology; Bachelor of Secondary Education; and Bachelor of Teacher Technology Education.

At the same time, his administration pursued **Certificate of Program Compliance (COPC)** from the **Commission on Higher Education (CHED)** across the system, with **MSU-Tawi-Tawi** achieving a landmark **100% COPC compliance** for all undergraduate programs evaluated, and MSU-Marawi advancing compliance in programs such as BS Environmental Science, BS Fisheries, BS Psychology, BS Mathematics, and BS Statistics.<ref name="msutcto">MSU-TCTO. (n.d.). *MSU-TCTO achieves 100% Certificate of Program Compliance.* https://msutcto.edu.ph/msu-tcto-achieves-100-certificate-of-program-compliance-on-all-undergraduate-programs-evaluated</ref><ref name="msumain-accred">Mindanao State University Main Campus. (n.d.). *MSU's accreditation pursuit: two days of intensive program evaluation and review.* https://www.msumain.edu.ph/msus-accreditation-pursuit-two-days-of-intensive-program-evaluation-and-review/</ref>

**Summary of Accreditation Milestones During the Macaayong Presidency (2016–2022)**

| Category | Highlights |
|---|---|
| **Level IV (AACCUP)** | BA English, BA Political Science, BA History, BS Psychology, Secondary Education (primarily at MSU-IIT) |
| **COPC (CHED)** | BS Agriculture, BS Forestry, BS Environmental Science, BS Business Administration; 100% compliance at MSU-TCTO |
| **Growth Milestone** | 40 programs reached Level I status by 2021, ranking MSU-Marawi No. 1 among SUCs nationally |

# Values and Leadership Philosophy

Dr. Macaayong's approach to leadership was shaped by two values he held consistently throughout his career: **meritocracy** and **compassion**.

He believed in rewarding hard work and qualifications with promotions and opportunities, as the faculty promotion drive demonstrated. But he also believed that compassion, especially toward students navigating poverty and crisis, had to be built into institutional policy, not just personal kindness.

That combination, principled structure paired with human warmth, is what many colleagues and students point to when they describe his leadership style.

His time as a peace negotiator deepened this. He'd spent years at the table between the government and the MILF, working on questions about who gets power and how it's shared. He understood that institutions either build trust or erode it, and he was determined that MSU would keep building it.

# Legacy

Dr. Habib Watamama Macaayong leaves behind a university system that is more accredited, better staffed, and more physically equipped than the one he inherited.

He steered MSU through the Marawi Siege and the COVID-19 pandemic, two of the most disruptive events in the university's modern history, and in both cases came out with the institution's mission intact and even strengthened.

His "Balik MSU" campaign is remembered not just as an operational success but as a cultural moment: a Meranaw institution declaring, in the aftermath of war, that education would not be surrendered to extremism.

The more than 900 faculty members who received long-overdue promotions during his watch, the 40 programs that achieved AACCUP Level I status, the fiber optic cables running across the Marawi campus, and the students who graduated during the pandemic under the Mass Promotion policy are all part of the same legacy: a university that

refused to stand still.

He is the **Peace President** of Mindanao State University, a title earned not in ceremony but in action, across thirty-five years of teaching, a decade of peace negotiations, and six years at the helm of one of the Philippines' most storied state universities.

# Recognition

- Named the **Top 1 Performing SUC** in the Philippines under the AACCUP accreditation system by 2021, under his leadership as MSU System President.<ref name="fb-msumain"/>
- Recognized nationally for his role as chairman of the technical working group on power sharing during the GPH-MILF peace negotiations (2004 to 2013).
- Credited by colleagues and the MSU community as the driving force behind the most comprehensive faculty promotion initiative in the university's recent history.

# Challenges

No honest account of Dr. Macaayong's presidency skips over the controversy surrounding his appointment.

His naming as MSU System President drew public criticism in some quarters, with questions raised about the selection process and the politics surrounding university leadership appointments.<ref name="inquirer-naming"/>

Beyond the appointment, governing a university in an active conflict zone presented challenges that no policy manual fully prepares a president for. The Marawi Siege tested every institutional system the university had, from its security protocols to its student records to its administrative continuity.

The COVID-19 pandemic added a second layer of disruption just as the university was rebuilding, forcing difficult decisions about academic standards, student welfare, and institutional survival.

That he navigated both without the university losing its footing says something about the depth of institutional trust he had built and the resilience of the community around him.

# See Also

- Mindanao State University
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- 2017 Marawi Siege
- Moro Islamic Liberation Front
- GPH-MILF Peace Process
- Meranaw people
- Lanao del Sur

# External Links

- PIA: Macaayong underscores MSU System's administrative reforms (https://mirror.pia.gov.ph/news/2021/10/28/macaayong-underscores-msu-systems-administrative-reforms)
- Inquirer: Naming of new MSU president draws fire (https://newsinfo.inquirer.net/780806/naming-of-new-msu-president-draws-fire)
- MSU-IIT News: Macaayong profile (https://www.msuiit.edu.ph/news/news-detail.php?id=771)

- MSU Main: Accreditation pursuit (https://www.msumain.edu.ph/msus-accreditation-pursuit-two-days-of-intensive-program-evaluation-and-review/)

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